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Building a maritime community with a shared future: Scholarly reflections on China's new ocean vision

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ABSTRACT

The initiative of Building a Maritime Community with a Shared Future (MCSF) has gained widespread attention domestically since it was proposed by President Xi Jinping in 2019. This article selects and reviews 269 academic articles published from 2019 to 2022 and classifies them according to their subjects. The paper, in four parts, makes reflections on building the MCSF from Chinese Academia. The introductory section describes the background of the MCSF. The second part explores a theoretical outlook of the literature on building the MCSF. Chinese scholars have examined the definition and specific contents of the MCSF. In addition, scholars further delve into the theoretical roadmaps of the MCSF including its theoretical foundation and promotion of international ocean governance theory. The third part analyses how to adopt a series of pragmatic approaches to build the MCSF in diverse ocean-related fields from both international and domestic perspectives. The fourth part gives concluding remarks.

1. Introduction

Global ocean governance is facing relatively few challenges in traditional and nontraditional maritime security issues [1]. In the major evolution of the strategic maritime landscape, the strategic game between late-developing maritime countries represented by China and traditional western maritime countries is beginning to emerge and is more comprehensive and complex than ever before [2].

As the primary source and authoritative document of the modern law of the sea, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS or the Convention) systematically and comprehensively formulates various legal regimes in the field of oceans and seas and is recognized as a global ocean charter [3]. However, the Convention, which focuses on resolving conflicts between the freedom of the oceans and the sovereignization of seas, displays loopholes and shortcomings in addressing the current nontraditional difficulties and challenges faced by global ocean governance [4].

At a critical moment when the world's strategic landscape is undergoing profound changes, the global ocean situation is complex and volatile, and ocean governance is meeting challenges, China has proposed the idea of the MCSF. On April 23, 2019, President Xi Jinping solemnly proposed the building of MCSF and stated that 'The blue planet that humans inhabit is not divided into islands by the oceans, but is connected by the oceans to form a community with a shared future, where people of all countries share weal and woe' [5]. In the following years, senior Chinese diplomats, on many occasions, continue to elaborate on the specific meaning at the official level. Foreign Minister Wang Yi, in the Symposium on Global Maritime Cooperation and Ocean Governance 2022, addressed that actions in the spirit of building the MCSF are taken to 'coordinate maritime development and security, and advance maritime cooperation and ocean governance' [6]. In the international conference marking the 40th anniversary of the opening for the signature of the UNCLOS, Foreign Minister Wang Yi emphasized that the purpose of building the MCSF is to 'to promote sustainable development of the sea' [7]. Ambassador Zhang Jun from the Permanent Mission of China to the United Nations also declared that 'the ocean connects the world into a community of mankind and is an important area of global governance' [8]. Accordingly, as an ocean governance concept, China considers the MCSF to be a cooperative, secure, developing, and sustainable notion. It does not overturn the current international maritime order but 'maintains the maritime order based on international law' [9]. Building the MCSF respects the central role of the UN in the international ocean governance, and enhances the well-being of all humankind [10].

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In general, Chinese scholars advocate the necessity of building the MCSF. Liu Wei further points out that countries should establish a new concept of common, integrated, cooperative, and sustainable security; strengthen solidarity and cooperation, and cooperate to create a maritime security pattern of equality and mutual trust and common construction and sharing [11]. This proposal emerged in response to serious threats to maritime security posed by piracy, maritime crime, marine disasters, and the spread of epidemics. In line with the needs of the era and the reality of the global maritime governance situation, China's proposal of building the MCSF not only points out a direction for the development of maritime affairs and its governance [12], but also provids an effective approach to comprehensive global ocean governance [13].

2. A theoretical outlook of the literature on building the MCSF

This part is presented in three sections and discusses a review of the literature on building the MCSF. The introductory section presents a statistical study of the current literature; the second section examines the concept and contents of the MCSF; lastly, the third section analyzes theoretical roadmaps based on the literature review for building the MCSF.

2.1. Statistical study of the literature on building the MCSF

The authors collected 269 articles published in 2019–2022 with a focus on the MCSF, which include 66 articles in 2020, 110 articles in 2021, 58 articles in 2022, which both represent 87% of the total papers. Furthermore, 35 articles were published in the second half of 2019. Therefore, the literature discussed in this study is dominated by publications from 2020 to 2022. The study broadly infers, in summary, that the number of articles published per year is mainly stable and exhibits a certain trend of growth (Chart 1).

These 269 articles are categorized according to their relevant topics. A few papers cover more than one topic; thus, the sum of the number of papers is more than 269. These articles mostly discuss approximately nine topics, namely, the concept of the MCSF; building the MCSF and international ocean governance theory and practice; building the MCSF and maritime security governance; building the MCSF and marine environmental governance; building the MCSF and biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction (BBNJ) governance; building the MCSF and Arctic governance; building the MCSF and Antarctic governance; building the MCSF and global commons governance, and the topic of China's engagement in international ocean governance by building the MCSF.

Chart 2 presents the distribution of topics, where the most frequently researched topic is China's engagement in international ocean governance and international ocean governance theory and practice at 26%, followed by building the MCSF and international ocean governance theory and practice at 23%. Building the MCSF and marine environment governance and the concept of the MCSF share nearly the same proportions at 14% and 12%, respectively. The remaining themes are all less than 10% (building the MCSF and maritime security governance at 8%; building the MCSF and BBNJ governance at 6%; and building the MCSF and global commons governance at 7%). Building the MCSF and Arctic or Antarctic governance represent 3% and 1% respectively. The statistics on the distribution of themes demonstrate an initial insight that the topic of China's engagement in international ocean governance and international ocean governance theory and practice are topics of high interest to scholars in terms of the literature on the MCSF.

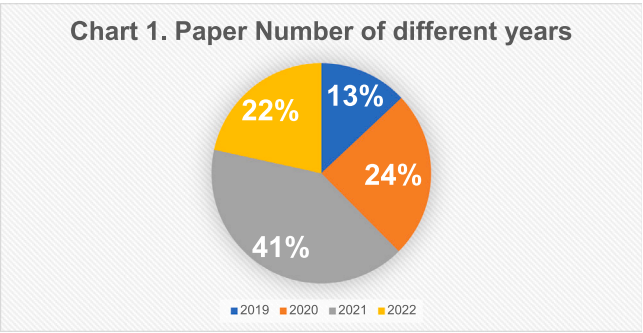

Chart 1. Paper Number of different years.

2.2. Study of the concept and contents of the MCSF

Scholars have examined the definition of MCSF from two perspectives: the first is the definition of the MCSF, and the second is the specific contents of the MCSF.

2.2.1. Concept of the MCSF

On 18 January 2017, Chinese President Xi Jinping delivered a keynote speech at the United Nations Office in Geneva, Switzerland. President Xi advocated that, 'China's proposition is' to 'build a community of shared future for mankind (CSFM) and achieve shared and win-win development'. The CSFM covers a wide range of topics: lasting peace, common security, common prosperity, common progress, common development. President Xi suggested the international community to 'promote partnership, security, growth, inter-civilization exchanges and the building of a sound ecosystem' [14]. Therefore, it represents China's grand vision of global governance and the way the world will develop in the future.

Pointing out that the definition of the MCSF cannot be without the concept of the CSFM as the root of the MCSF, Zhu Xiong states that 'the MCSF is a refinement and deepening of the CSFM concept' [15]. Zhu Feng argues that 'the CSFM is the development goal of the MCSF, and the MCSF is the concrete practice of the CSFM' [16]. Jin Yongming holds the opinion that 'the values and vision of goals advocated by the MCSF are consistent with the concept, principles and spirit embodied in the concept of the CSFM' [17]. Furthermore, Zhu Feng believes that the MCSF embodies the new historical and theoretical heights of the diplomatic thought of President Xi, whose single main content is to promote inclusive multilateralism cooperation on the basis of equality and mutual benefit [18]. Wang Yiwei interprets the concept of MCSF in three aspects: 'the ocean is itself a community of shared future; humanity and the ocean collectively represent a community of shared future; and the ocean further represents a conduit of the community of shared humanity' [19].

2.2.2. Contents of the MCSF

Although the specific vocabulary used by different scholars varies, in general, the content of the MCSF includes maritime peace (peaceful settlement of disputes), security (freedom of navigation, sea passage, counter-terrorism, and maritime crimes), environment (protection, preservation, and conservation), and prosperity (economy and science) [20]. Chinese scholars conduct in-depth interpretations and analyses of the concept of the MCSF from various dimensions.

Yuan Sha briefly summarizes the content of the MCSF as safeguarding the marine environment, guarding marine security, protecting marine ecology, and caring for the blue home [21]. Although the expression is different, Yao Ying also presents a very similar observation by stating that the concept of MCSF includes 'Ocean Security Community', 'Ocean Interest Community', 'Ocean Ecological Community', and 'Ocean Peace and Harmony Community' [22]. Meng Xiaoyu and Zhang Jingquan further point out that the establishment of a just and stable maritime order is one of the goals of the MCSF, and the posture of harmonious maritime relations pursued by the maritime order is also the rightful meaning of the MCSF [23]. Moreover, Wang Rujun and Wang Dan consider the concept of the MCSF as logical, profound, and complete, and its generation comes from a complete theoretical, realistic, and historical logic [24]. It includes five dimensions, namely, marine

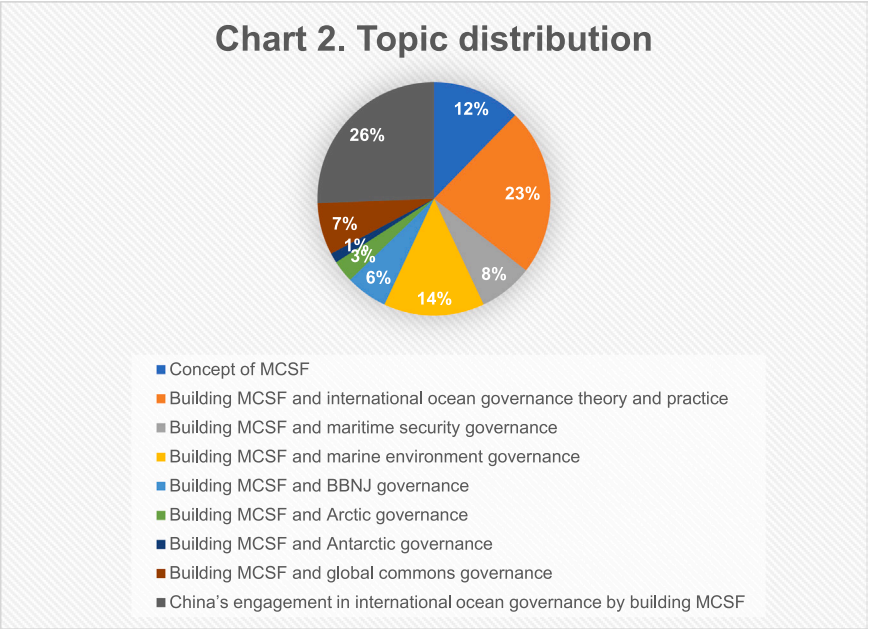

Chart 2. Topic distribution.

politics, economy, culture, ecology, and security, with the theoretical character of the times, scientific spirit, practical nature, people's sentiment, and international vision.

2.3. *Theoretical roadmaps in the literature review on building the MCSF*

Theoretical roadmaps contain literature related to the theoretical foundation and promotion of the MCSF to international ocean governance theory.

2.3.1. *Theoretical foundation of the MCSF*

Beyond the discussion of the concept of the MCSF, scholars are concerned with its theoretical foundations. Scholars of international relations and international law understand and interpret the theoretical basis of the concept of the maritime fate community from unique perspectives. The theoretical analysis of the concept of the maritime community has become an important part of the relevant literature on MCSF. This section provides an in-depth discussion of the theoretical foundations of the maritime community from the cross-disciplinary perspective of studies conducted by scholars of international law and international relations.

2.3.1.1. Political foundation. As previously mentioned, the CSFM was considered an important theoretical basis for the MCSF. Although it was first proposed as belonging to the political field, it was subsequently found to be applicable to the context of international law as well and became one of the important foundations of the MCSF. For example, Chen Sijing argues that Xi Jinping's important statement on the CSFM fits the contemporary context of the development of international law, which reflects the theme of the times, that is, 'peace, development, and cooperation,' and possesses the unique values of international law [25]. Chen Xiuwu argues that the MCSF addresses the issue of 'relations, actions, and structures' and is a development and deepening of 'cooperation theory' and 'integration theory' in the theory of international relations [26]. From a Marxist perspective, Tang Gang holds that 'MCSF is the latest achievement of Marx's discourse on the sea and the Chineseization of Marx's community theory' [27]. Furthermore, Liu Changming and Zhou Mingzhu observe that 'the principle of communality embedded in public ownership is a basis for building an MCSF' [28]. Meanwhile, Li Guoxuan highly regards the MCSF as a new world view of the oceans and a promising new scheme of the world maritime order [29]. Moreover, it completes the transcendence of western maritime power theory at least from three levels, namely, participation, target orientation, and construction path, and opens up a new era of global maritime political theory.

2.3.1.2. Legal foundation. From the legal perspective, scholars discuss the theoretical foundations of the MCSF in international law and what it entails at the international law level. Zou Keyuan believes that the connotation of the CSFM in international law can be summarized as the organic combination of the original international law system (the idea of the community), traditional Chinese culture, and the value objectives of China's international relations in the new era [30]. Ma Jinxing states that building the MCSF converges the consensus on global ocean governance with the theory of entire humanity and common interests [31]. Moreover, it follows the common human values of peaceful development, fairness and justice, and democracy and freedom, and it advocates the construction of an open and inclusive international ocean order based on the United Nations Charter and the five principles of peaceful coexistence. Ma Deyi explains the concept of the MCSF through a quantitative analysis of maritime legal rights. He argues that the maritime legal order integrated into the concept of the MCSF should be a maritime governance order in which all countries bear responsibilities and obligations under international law [32]. Alternatively, Chang Yen-Chiang demonstrates the theoretical basis of the concept of the MCSF in modern maritime law from three dimensions, namely, common interests, common values, and joint responsibility [33]. Moreover, he believes that its core spirit continues to be conducting activities in an area for the interests of human beings as a whole, and it is embodied in the concept of good marine governance as well as emphasized by joint responsibility [34].

2.3.1.3. Cultural and sociological foundations. MCSF not only derives its theoretical foundation in the system of international relations and international law but is also rooted in deep cultural heritage and connotation. Many scholars devote themselves to the study of the cultural roots of the MCSF, and their papers form an important part of the literature on the MCSF. Xu Wenyu opines that the concept of the MCSF embodies the vitality concepts of 'harmony between people and the sea' and 'tolerance and coexistence' in marine culture [35]. Moreover, the

MCSF creatively applies the essence of an excellent Chinese marine culture to the deep-seated knowledge and high levels of understanding of the ocean and its development. In their article, Chen Ling and Chen Li mention that the Chinese cultural concept of harmony is the main line of the Chinese Ideology; the pursuit of harmonious thinking is the guide; and the modern value of the concept of harmony is inherited in the construction of the East Asian MCSF [36]. This notion is reflective of the creative transformation and innovative development of the traditional Chinese culture. Duan Yiran and Ren Wenfeng also agree that MCSF is an inheritance and development of the excellent Chinese Traditional culture and thought [37]. Two authors further put forward that promoting the excellent Chinese culture and building the MCSF are necessary for solving the various problems of global maritime development. Wang Libing believes that oceanic civilization is a supersocial system that includes many societies, and differences and consistency exist across societies and civilization phenomena covered by such societies [38]. MCSF pertains to a profound understanding and enhancement of the essential attributes and characteristics of oceanic civilization and is an effective method for addressing oceanic issues in the context of nation-states. Wang Shuming and Dong Zhaoxin point out that the maritime worldview is a new understanding and interpretation of the entire world from the perspective of the ocean and not only of the ocean itself [39]. Moreover, President Xi's MCSF theory is a 'maritime worldview' that is consciously constructed at the level of 'civilization-like'. It will promote exchanges and mutual appreciation among world civilizations and the common development of mankind. Conversely, Hua Ying and Cai Qinyu demonstrate the long history of the Chinese people in developing and sharing the sea by reviewing a series of Chinese maritime activities from the early Han Dynasty and through the Tang, Song, and Yuan Dynasties. At the same time, two authors cite examples of the ban on maritime activities during the Ming and Qing Dynasties to illustrate the impact of the decline of maritime activities on the backwardness of China in modern times [40].

On another note, Song Ninger and Zhang Cong argue that elaborating the concept of the MCSF only from the perspectives of geopolitics, international law, and Marxist theory, among others, is insufficient. The sociological perspective, as the main research topic of community, must be included in the discussion of this issue. Both authors propose that focus must be directed to the MCSF from the sociological perspective and suggest that this perspective requires a definition of the relationship between the MCSF and the 'ocean community', both of which are formed in practice. Both differ in terms of meaning, practice guidelines, and perspectives of observation. However, such differences do not imply that the theories of the ocean society are irrelevant to the theoretical construction of the MCSF. On the contrary, the theory of marine sociology can enrich the connotation of the MCSF and provide additional dimensions and frameworks, which can be called the value and significance of sociological perspective on the MCSF, due to the differences between them [41].

2.3.2. *Theoretical contribution of MCSF to international ocean governance theory*

2.3.2.1. Political perspective. Scholars have affirmed the important role and undeniable value of the MCSF in international relations and global governance. As Zhu Feng says, 'MCSF is of great significance in promoting cooperation and coordination among countries in the process of maritime governance' [42]. Many scholars, such as Lin Kunyong et al., have reached a consensus that a proposal of the MCSF includes Chinese wisdom and solutions contributed by China's active participation in global ocean governance [43]. Ma Jinxing cites that responding to changes in the world's ocean landscape using the concept of the MCSF will promote a more equitable, reasonable, and balanced global ocean governance system [44].

2.3.2.2. Legal perspective. At present, the rule of law of marine information is facing problems, such as the fragmentation of the system, obsolescence of the concept, and low end of the international rule of law, which seriously hinder the development process of the rule of law of marine information. The MCSF provides a new theoretical source and a scientific methodological theory for the construction of the rule of law of ocean information. In the construction, not only the common interests of human beings but also human morality and righteousness should be analyzed and pursued by considering profit and righteousness [45]. Chen Sijing points out that the evolution of the current international law of the sea rules is making the legal regime of the global maritime commons, such as the 'International Seabed Area', more and more perfect [46]. In addition, the practice of the MCSF concept not only safeguards China's maritime rights and interests in the process but also renders the design of the law of the sea rules in line with the common interests of all mankind. Wei Jianxun summarizes four kinds of values in building the MCSF. It has a normative value, which can resolve the paradox of national and global interests; It has a behavioral value, which can coalesce global ocean governance synergy; It has a systemic value, which can promote comprehensive ocean governance; It has a motivational value, which can promote sustainable ocean development [47].

3. Practical roadmaps in the literature on building the MCSF

Scholars focus on the application of the MCSF in practice, and several parts can be used to depict practical roadmaps in the process of building the MCSF. The first subsection presents a summary of approaches to building the MCSF for the objective of promoting ocean governance at the international level. The second section derives from the domestic perspective and examines the promotion of China's internal ocean governance by building the MCSF in practice. The roadmap proposed by Chinese academics for building the MCSF differs in some respects from the international ocean governance process. By building the MCSF, China will take advantage of the existing marine governance platform and promote global ocean governance more effectively. Chinese scholars are inclined to discuss the MCSF's comparative advantages. In short, the MCSF's primary objective is to facilitate the development of new governance concepts for international ocean governance.

3.1. *Approaches to building the MCSF in the promotion of ocean governance from the international perspective*

3.1.1. *How building the MCSF promotes ocean governance from the macro perspective*

As previously mentioned, the MCSF is a positive reflection of China's active participation in global ocean governance. Many Chinese scholars focus on the impact and contribution of the MCSF to global governance and offer observations and assessments from various angles.

Fu Mengzi and Wang Li recommend that, to build the MCSF, all stakeholders should stand in the common interest of mankind and expand consensus; A stronger rule of law concept is needed; Efforts should be made to create a peaceful and cooperative ocean; Developing better ocean science and technology provides effective and reliable technical support for ocean governance [48]. Zhu Qin and Gao Lan state that, 'MCSF as an integral part of CSFM and its development in the maritime field, describes a new maritime power and a new maritime order that is de-hegemonic, and is a watershed in the transformation of maritime power from monopoly to sharing, from tradition to new' [49]. Liu Wei believes that MCSF is a breakthrough in the Western-dominated international ocean theory, which exceeds the simple and narrow claim of ocean rights and interests enjoyed by one country and one nation alone [50]. This notion reflects China's deep concern for global ocean governance and even global governance. From the perspective of specific governance issues, He Zhipeng and Geng Siwen point out the shortcomings of the existing international law on global ocean governance based on the issue of marine environmental pollution. They

propose that 'the concept of MCSF is a Chinese response to provide overall protection for the common interests of countries in the marine environment and solve the problems of marine governance, which can provide new ideas and make useful contributions to global marine environmental governance. The concept of MCSF should be used as a guide to promoting global marine environmental governance' [51]. Chen Yitong is concerned about the dilemma of applying the UNCLOS on the issue of rising sea levels and suggested that China should take the concept of MCSF as its guiding ideology [52]. Moreover, the country should deeply participate in the international law-making process to take the lead in international rule-making and propose China's practical solutions to systematically address the challenges of international law with regard to rising sea levels.

Furthermore, Wu Wei opines that China improves its marine-related legal system through a series of maritime practices. The concept of the MCSF, which is proposed for global maritime governance issues, can contribute to the global maritime governance and rule system [53]. In another article, Wu Wei adds that, 'through initiatives such as maritime legislation, revision of existing maritime laws, active participation in the development of international maritime laws and rules, and resolute defense of the international maritime rule of law, it has contributed to global ocean governance and the building of MCSF' [54]. Tang Gang views the MCSF as a pathway for the realization of the global ocean governance of Xi Jinping's theory, which provides guidance for the transformation of global ocean governance [55]. In addition, it contributed Chinese wisdom to the resolution of ocean disputes as well as pointed the way to the establishment of a new ocean order. In his article, Pang Zhongying says, starting from the understanding of the relationship between global governance (global ocean governance) and world peace (global ocean peace) and how China can move toward world ocean peace through its participation in global ocean governance, China is already an important national actor in world ocean peace and is in fact already advancing a new international concordance in the field of ocean [56].

From another dimension, Liu Xiaowei states that the MCSF is a combination of global ocean governance, regional ocean governance, and cooperation in ocean governance among countries [57]. However, Duan Ke and Yu Jing even make bold speculation that the idea may dominate the future international maritime order [58]. In contrast to these authors, Ye Quan believes that China's proposal is an improvement instead of a reversal of the existing ocean governance system, that is, a more equitable and reasonable international ocean legal order based on the positive effects of the existing ocean governance system [59]. Alternatively, Zhai Kun selects a new angle and evaluated the internal and external perspectives of China on the basis of this idea. He believes that this concept can be internally viewed as a major development in China's strategy of building the CSFM and strengthening the ocean since the 18th Party Congress. Externally, it is viewed as a major development of China's solution to participate in global ocean governance [60]. Conversely, a number of scholars narrow their vision from global ocean governance to specific regional contexts and discussed the implications and significance of building an ocean community of destiny in a specific region for regional governance, cooperation, and development. Guan Yecheng and Wang Xiaojie conducts a review of the history and current status of maritime exchange and communication among East Asian countries and the prospect for the construction of the MCSF in East Asia [61]. Wang Gaoyang points out that, the rise of China in the 21st century and the expansion of its maritime influence have brought an important opportunity for the transformation of the East Asian maritime order. By providing new forces, norms and ideas for the construction of the regional maritime order, China has increasingly become an active and indispensable force in the process of constructing the maritime order in East Asia [62]. Bai Jiayu argues that, the interests upheld by the UNCLOS show a trend of evolving from national interests to the common interests of all mankind. Against this background, China adheres to the concept of maritime community of destiny based on the community of human destiny, strives to become an advocate, builder and contributor to the international maritime order based on international law, and provides 'Chinese proposal' on issues of the law of the sea that are closely related to the common interests of all mankind, such as common response to climate change, exploitation of resources in international seabed areas and conservation of biodiversity in the high seas [63].

3.1.2. *How building the MCSF promotes ocean governance from the micro perspective*

A few scholars focus on specific intercountry cooperation within a region guided by MCSF theory. Scholars suggest that building the MCSF should be based on the 'point–line–dimension geographical mode' with an integrated 'short–medium–long-term plan' [64]. Liang Jiarui proposes that to promote Sino–French cooperation on marine governance in the South Pacific and further build a community of maritime destiny, both sides should take the South Pacific Regional Environment Agency as a platform for cooperation on marine environmental protection in the South Pacific. Examples include jointly setting up a funding platform to address climate change in the South Pacific and standardizing the financing mechanism, promoting the establishment of a marine biodiversity protection mechanism, and strengthening cooperation on blue carbon governance [65]. Gao Lan believes that, in recent years and under the guidance of the concept of the MCSF, the maritime situation between China and Japan developed from fierce confrontation to negative cooperation and even positive cooperation. At the same time, according to the third phase of the 'Ocean Basic Plan', Japan proposes to face the 'challenge of new ocean power' and strive for international maritime cooperation. To this end, the China–Japan maritime cooperation ushered in new opportunities and additional room for cooperation [66].

3.1.2.1. A. Maritime security governance. The increasing number and severity of global maritime security issues are one of the important backgrounds for the proposal of MCSF theory. Therefore, the understanding and analysis of the relationship between MCSF and marine security governance is an extremely important and indispensable part of the research on MCSF. Analyses of this issue are broadly divided into two levels, namely, international and regional marine security.

3.1.2.1.1. International maritime security. New opportunities and challenges for global maritime security governance are both evident at present and ushered in a new historical turning point. Global actors need to promote the new development of global ocean security governance in terms of updating the concept of development governance, conducting substantive multilateral collaboration, and exploring other practical development models [67]. The concept and practice of the MCSF, as proposed by China, is a novel international maritime norm that meets the needs of the times and the reality of the dynamics of global ocean governance [68]. Zhang Ying provides a comprehensive observation on the interpretation and understanding of maritime security. At the national level, maritime security is an important part of China's overall national security concept; at the regional level, China's perception of maritime security has expanded the scope of China's peripheral security and peripheral diplomacy; at the global level, China's maritime security practice is an important attempt for China to provide global maritime public goods and participate in global maritime governance [69].

In November 2017, at the first working meeting between the Chinese and the Philippines maritime police forces, the two sides clearly proposed to cooperate to build a 'maritime security community of destiny'. Xu Zhengyuan suggests that the 'maritime security community of destiny' is a 'community of risks in security', a 'community of interests in maritime cooperation', and a 'community of ideas in politics' [70]. It not only contains the established concepts of Chinese diplomacy, such as multilateral cooperation but also innovatively develops new concepts of maritime security governance, such as common development and the

concept of common maritime security. This notion, thus, becomes a practical pointer for China in promoting global maritime security governance. Focusing on the global public health security crisis, Yin Yanqi believes that the concept of the MCSF, as proposed by President Xi Jinping, provides a new theoretical framework for the global governance model of public health [71]. At the same time, the public health diplomacy carried out by maritime hospital ships provides a concrete path for the MCSF to be put into practice. Therefore, examining public health diplomacy in the context of the MCSF will help China effectively participate in international mechanisms for health security and constructively promote the building of the CSFM. In the current legal system of international cooperation in maritime crisis management, the main body is still the international organization represented by the United Nations, and its legal framework is composed of the international legal system with the UNCLOS at the core [72]. Yang Zewei believes that this has led to 'the fragmentation of the legal system, the constraints of national jurisdiction and the ambiguity of its contents'. To a certain extent, the concept of the MCSF is an important aspect of improving the legal system of international cooperation in maritime crisis management. It will promote changes in international cooperation in relation to maritime crisis management [73]. Cao Hongjun et al. analyze the relationship between marine ecological safety and the MCSF. They argue that maintaining marine ecological safety is the basis for the building of the MCSF. Conversely, this act is a means for countries to jointly maintain marine ecological safety, and the two complement each other to jointly solve global marine problems [74].

The MCSF provides new ideas and theoretical support for global governance. Building the MCSF also requires a solid practical and theoretical foundation, which cannot be achieved without the joint efforts of the international community. Based on this discussion, scholars further explore how the international community can better utilize MCSF theories to improve global governance and apply it to practice and theory development.

Under the guidance of the concept of the MCSF, the international community should improve and develop the international law of the sea by elucidating the maritime security regime. Moreover, it can formulate regulations on the development of maritime areas beyond national jurisdiction, improve the marine ecological and environmental protection regime beyond national jurisdiction, and enrich the system of peaceful settlement of maritime disputes. In this manner, the development of the international maritime rule of law can be promoted in a just and reasonable direction [75]. Zhu Xiong argues that in terms of building the MCSF, expanding the common consciousness is important, followed by the principle of 'Consultation, Contribution, and Shared Benefits'. Moreover, attention should be paid to the manner of expression and the construction of the field of discourse. At the same time, the focus should be directed on drawing on traditional historical wisdom and respecting civilizational differences [76]. Wang Fang and Wang Luying also observe that the key to promoting MCSF lies in advocating multilateralism and international cooperation, encouraging transposition, confronting major global maritime issues, and, ultimately, building a consensus to form a global community of maritime interests, responsibilities, and destiny [77].

3.1.2.1.2. Regional maritime security. In addition to the research on international maritime security and the MCSF, Chinese scholars have also conducted numerous studies on maritime security issues in specific regions, such as East Asia and the South China Sea, as well as specific intraregional and interstate maritime activities guided by a maritime community of destiny. Gong Lili and Ye Xiaohan point out that, at present, issues such as territorial and maritime rights and interests are hindering traditional maritime security cooperation in the East Asian region, and factors such as the involvement of extraterritorial countries, especially the US, and differences in the maritime capabilities of regional countries are also affecting the development of maritime security cooperation in East Asia [78].

However, the introduction of a trust mechanism under the guidance of the concept of the MCSF can provide a new path for maritime security in East Asia. With regard to the security situation in the South China Sea, Jiang He believes that a one-sided application of strategies, such as extraregional judicial activism, has led to the security dilemma in the South China Sea region. In this regard, the new concept of a common, integrated, cooperative, and sustainable security held by the concept of a community of human destiny can help achieve universal security in the South China Sea. 'The joint construction of the Belt and Road will move the basic value of international law from negative peace to positive peace premised on universal security, laying the social foundation for security cooperation in the South China Sea region' [79]. Hong Nong indicates that although some legal commonalities can be seen in the attitudes of South China Sea countries toward international law, their participation in the law of the sea negotiation process, domestic maritime legislation, and dispute settlement practices, the South China Sea arbitration case and the resulting regional security instability have exposed the reality of the lack of legal and cultural commonality in the South China Sea region [80]. Li Nai and Li Zhiwen argue that, the MCSF with its core concept of benefit sharing, responsibility sharing and safe co-construction, enhances the willingness of search and rescue cooperation among South China Sea countries and creates a more equal and inclusive cooperation platform. Building the MCSF helps the South China Sea countries to make the rules system of search and rescue more cooperative. It also suggests to diversify the participation of regional countries for search and rescue cooperation in South China Sea [81].

Feng Liang believes that 'under the provocation and compulsion of the US, the situation in the South China Sea is still uncertain and unstable, and there is the possibility of a maritime confrontation or even a conflict between China and the US'. Nonetheless, the future trend of the South China Sea strategy is to develop cooperation under the guidance of the concept of a maritime community of destiny and to defend the core interests of China in the South China Sea [82]. After observing the maritime security issues between China and India, Li Tao and Zhang Qiu Rong mention that, as the maritime interaction between China and India becomes increasingly frequent, the security dilemma between the two countries gradually extends from land to sea, which seriously affects China's ability to create a stable and peaceful surrounding environment. The construction of the China–India maritime community of destiny under the guidance of the concept of the community of human destiny, which updates the concept of maritime security and establishes a mechanism of mutual trust in security, may alleviate the maritime security dilemma between China and India [83]. Other scholars also advocate the strengthening of maritime cooperation between China and other countries to improve interstate relations and promote the building of the MCSF. For example, Zhang Xiaolei suggests building a constructive security relationship between China and Japan by strengthening nontraditional security cooperation in the overall cooperation framework and specific dialog and cooperation mechanisms. Moreover, the sequence of cooperation areas and the type of joint exercises and training models can be improved [84]. He Jian et al. argue that China's cooperation with East Africa on the security of maritime energy corridors is of great significance. In addition, despite challenges, such as limited governance capacity and inadequate legal systems in East African countries, the continued persistence and development of this cooperation will promote the establishment of a maritime community of destiny [85].

3.1.3. Marine environment governance

Marine environmental issues remain important issues in marine development, and building a marine ecological community is one of the important contents of the concept of the MCSF. The study of the marine destiny community from the perspective of ecological civilization is of great theoretical and practical value. Under the theoretical system of the MCSF, Chinese scholars analyze, interpret, and suggest specific marine environmental issues that are prominent nowadays. In addition, the marine environmental protection measures of other countries are

evaluated from the perspective of the MCSF. Finally, scholars discuss the construction, development, and improvement of the global marine ecosystem.

Zhang Hua contends that, the judicial consolidation of international maritime environmental law is instructive for China to promote the building of the MCSF. The compulsory procedures under the dispute settlement mechanism of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) provide an institutionalized operating field for this judicial strengthening. Therefore, guided by the MCSF, China should play a constructive role in the global ocean governance process and implement the goal of sustainable ocean development [86]. Bai Jiayu and Sui Jiaxin argue that ocean acidification is an emerging marine environmental problem at the global level. Although general international laws and regulations are applicable to this problem, systematic laws and regulations for managing ocean acidification from the aspect of the marine environment are lacking. Furthermore, a shortage of specialized laws is observed. Thus, two authors suggest that this issue should be included in the agenda for international negotiations on issues of common interest to mankind [87]. In addition, the MCSF concept could be used to promote international cooperation in addressing ocean acidification. In recent years, Japan's deliberate release of nuclear wastewater and other marine wastes into the sea has caused countries around the ocean to pay more attention to the problem of marine waste pollution. According to Chen Lin and Pan Guoping, 'international rules on marine waste pollution are scattered and incomplete, and most of the relevant treaties only address a particular aspect of the activity'. They also point to gaps in cross-border transfers. For example, the Basel Convention mentions dispute settlement mechanisms but lacks remedies and compensation methods. At the same time, the primacy of the principle of national interests of internationalist countries renders international treaties a 'result of compromises around the interests of the major powers' [88]. The scholars proposed that the prevention and improvement of the legal regulation of marine waste can be conducted at three levels, namely, systematic coordination and cooperation mechanisms, clarification of legal mechanisms for preventing and controlling marine waste pollution, and the construction of a reasonable model of marine waste pollution management. In line with the background of the MCSF, the future trend for solving new pollution problems, such as microplastic pollution, is the adoption of a multicorporate governance model. The Montreal Protocol, which is a document on combating the degradation of the ozone layer, can provide a reference for oceans, which are also mobile and holistic, and provide directions for the construction of a shared governance model in terms of prevention and posttreatment [89]. Cui Ye and Sun Kai agree on the efforts of the international community in combating plastic pollution and confirm the outcome achieved [90]. In addition, Sun Kai emphasizes that stakeholders should adhere to the principle of joint participation of multiple subjects, play the joint role of multiple actors, and build a multilevel governance mechanism with the joint participation of multiple subjects [91].

Jiang Xiaoyi and He Jie present Malaysia's initiative to establish a "National Ocean Park" in the Lukangan Sands under the pretext of environmental protection [92]. This project aims to strengthen the possession and control of disputed waters and geographical objects in the South China Sea, for example, to demonstrate that achieving the effectiveness of cooperation in the construction of marine protected areas (MPAs) is difficult due to the divergent interests of countries. However, the concept of the MCSF may exert a positive effect on the construction and cooperation of MPAs at the international level, in disputed waters, and within jurisdictional waters. Zhu Yongqian and Zhang Weibin point out that governance of the marine ecological environment requires the establishment of a multisubject co-management model [93]. The concept of the MCSF should be used as the guiding concept of this model, which helps to realize the construction of this model by elucidating the scope of the plural subjects of the marine ecological environment and by establishing the principle of pollution prevention and the coordination mechanism of governance of plural subjects, among others. In another article, the same authors focus on the details of the construction process and put forward that the discourse claims, benefit distribution claims, and conceptual claims of subjects in a system require full consideration in the design of key elements. Moreover, a corresponding evaluation system needs to be established [94].

Quan Yongbo and Sheng Huijuan focus on the rule of law system of marine ecology and environment and proposed the promotion and improvement of the construction of the rule of the law system for marine ecology and the environment from four perspectives, namely, legislative, law enforcement, judicial institutions and system, and law-abiding system [95]. Chang Yen-Chiang and Sun Yue find that, the UNCLOS encourages all countries to conduct marine scientific research in accordance with the principle of protecting and preserving the marine environment. Through building the MCSF, countries can seek international cooperation to improve their capabilities for marine scientific research, which help overcome shortcomings in the development of marine scientific research [96].

Chang Yen-Chiang and Shi Caiyang believe that for such a complex issue as global marine ecology and environmental governance, system theory should be used as a guide, and system thinking logic should be used, which requires governance subjects to regard the global ocean as a system; view the issue from a holistic, connected, and developmental perspective; and follow the principles and characteristics of the system structure and function to implement governance [97]. The concept of building the MCSF is highly consistent with the spirit of system theory in terms of value orientation. By taking the common interests of mankind as the basis for development, the concept of the MCSF is conducive to understanding the direction of marine ecological environment governance as a whole, coordinating the interests of parties worldwide, and seeking a fair distribution of benefits in the midst of conflicts, which is precisely the requirement of the principle of the wholeness of system theory[97].

3.1.4. *Biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction (BBNJ) governance*

The MCSF derives its theoretical basis from the UNCLOS, which is considered the *charter of the oceans*, and the BBNJ mechanism, as an extension of the UNCLOS, will become an important element of global marine ecosystem governance.

Leading the negotiation of the BBNJ international agreement and overcoming the main challenges encountered in the current negotiations are of great significance to the participation of China in global marine ecosystem governance [98]. BBNJ continues to face practical dilemmas, such as the weakening of international cooperation due to the weak sense of responsibility of the subjects of affairs; the different perceptions of diverse subjects regarding the basic principles of the law of the sea that led to the emergence of new conflicts; and the difficulty of reaching agreement on all contents of the agreement. Thus, China should utilize the concept of the CSFM to provide a value base for global ocean governance, which can help the negotiation of the BBNJ agreement on the one hand and can establish China's international image as a responsible power in global ocean governance on the other hand [99]. Hu Bin argues that, based on its understanding of the causes, China should be guided by the concept of a community of human destiny to resolve the current impasse in the negotiation of agreements between developing and developed countries, which is a north–south confrontation [100]. Li Jie proposes that regional regimes have demonstrated advantages in the process of BBNJ global governance but need to further strengthen mutual cooperation [101]. As it participates in the negotiations of the BBNJ agreement, China should also pay attention to and examine the future trends of the regional maritime regime.

Liu Huirong and Qi Xuewei seek a response to the question of whether or not the principle of the common heritage of mankind is included in the general principles or methodological provisions of BBNJ international agreements [102]. Two authors suggest that China should pose a supportive attitude in this regard and introduce the concept of the

CSFM into BBNJ international agreements as a value orientation. Furthermore, the country should push for the CSFM to enter into force and also use the concept of CSFM to enhance the principle of the common heritage of mankind in the negotiations. In the consultation stage, the BBNJ agreement provides a good opportunity for realizing the institutional arrangement of the concept of the MCSF. Thus, China should strengthen the maritime rule of law construction internally and lead the negotiation of the BBNJ agreement externally [103].

3.1.5. Polar region governance

Global climate change has led to environmental problems such as the depletion of the ozone layer and rising sea levels. The issue of the integrated management of the Antarctic and Arctic is gradually attracting the attention of increasing numbers of governments and scholars in the context of rising global temperatures. The concept of the MCSF proposed by China is a new way of thinking and a new path for solving the problem of polar governance under this dilemma.

The dynamics of Arctic governance under climate warming is facing a contradiction between the self-management of the Arctic Council, which is dominated by Arctic states, and international synergy, which denotes new Arctic governance mechanisms formed by extraterritorial states and organizations by establishing forums and concluding treaties [104]. As a stakeholder in the Arctic and with the important mission of maintaining peace and security in the Arctic, China should promote the concept of a community of destiny as an important basis for addressing affairs related to the Arctic and strive to promote the construction of an "Arctic community with a shared future" [105]. Zhang Cheng argues that, from the perspective of global public goods, environmental governance, and economic governance, Arctic route governance has similar characteristics to the CSFM. In accordance with existing international rules, the implementation of the CSFM, together with the MCSF, can help promote the formation and improvement of a multilateral cooperative governance system for Arctic route [106].

Yang Zhenjiao and Han Qi suggest that, the Arctic practice guided by national egoism can no longer meet the real needs of Arctic governance, and the concept of CSFM, the new concept of national security, and the concept of ecopolitics present a fit in guiding Arctic governance activities; thus, providing a new theoretical basis for Chinese participation in Arctic governance [107]. Bai Jiayu speculates that the controversy over the application of the Spitsbergen Treaty and the issues behind it reflect a distribution of benefits between Norway and the other Contracting States that is not in line with fair values. She further states that, the CSFM concept, with the guarantee of shared responsibility and the objective of seeking the maximum common denominator of the common interests of the parties, is conducive to reducing the divergence of interests among the parties and to maintaining and promoting the stability of the equitable system of the Spitsbergen Treaty [108].

Tang Yao and Xia Liping contend that, strengthening regional fisheries management organizations and the development of the High Seas Fisheries Agreement enshrine the concept of the CSFM [109]. Chen Yitong and Gao Xiao argue that UNCLOS and a series of international organizations and international legal instruments, which are based on issues, constitute the international mechanism that is concerned with the utilization of marine resources in the Arctic. However, UNCLOS ignores the holistic nature of the ocean, such that resolving the contradiction between resource utilization and marine ecological environment protection is difficult. The Arctic Council plays a coordinating role in the governance of marine resource utilization, but its regionalist governance path lacks consideration of external interests, common human interests, and overall interests of the ocean. Thus, China should use the MCSF as a basis for broadening the multidimensional channels of Arctic governance and safeguarding its national interests in the Arctic region [110].

After summarizing and analyzing the current challenges of Antarctic governance and reviewing the process of establishing Antarctic protected areas, Fu Yu believes that extensive participation in affairs related to MPAs in the Antarctic, improving the legal system of domestic MPAs, and vigorously strengthening scientific research on marine ecology and environment in the Antarctic can help China better face the differences and contradictions in the legal system, political factors, scientific basis, and monitoring of MPAs in the Antarctic. Furthermore, it can implement the important concept of the CSFM and fulfill the obligations of member countries of the Convention on the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources [111]. In an interview, Dr. Wang Wanlu summarizes opinions on the relationship between Antarctic governance and the construction of the MCSF by citing several contemporary scholars: Yang Jian and others analyze the connotation of CSFM and suggested building a community of destiny for the new frontier through international cooperation including the Antarctic in institution building, peaceful use, scientific exploration and community building [112]. Liu Huirong analyzes the concept of community and believed that building a community is the ethical basis for Antarctic governance [113]. Li Xueping believes that Antarctica is the best option to practice the concept of CSFM [114].

3.1.6. Global commons governance

The global ocean commons are characterized by the unattributed nature of sovereignty, nonexclusive and competitive use, and regulated use. These areas do not belong to any country or region but are shared by mankind. However, with the increase in human activities in the global ocean commons, a series of problems are gradually emerging within the global ocean commons. As such, its governance is on the agenda, which requires countries and international organizations to formulate a plan based on the realization of common interests.

The concept of the MCSF, the principle of inclusion and the consultation of governance subjects, the principle of pluralism and the regulation of governance methods, and the principle of sharing the benefits of governance are responses to the challenges of the politicization of power, the deficit in governance supply, and the privatization of governance value orientation in terms of governance over the global ocean commons [115]. Marine environmental protection on high seas is an issue that exceeds national jurisdiction; thus, international treaties or agreements cannot fundamentally address the deteriorating situation of the marine environment on these high seas. As such, building the MCSF is an effective method for China to address the principle of the supremacy of national interests in the internationalism of marine environmental protection in common seas and the free-rider approach to international governance [116].

The Draft Regulations on the Exploitation of Mineral Resources in the Area (the Draft Regulations) is being formulated, and China should take the initiative in the process of international rule-making. In this manner, it can obtain a special status for incorporating the concept of the MCSF into the Draft Regulations [117]. The review mechanism proposed by the International Seabed Authority in the Draft Regulations is a partial deviation from the spirit of the UNCLOS. However, the MCSF is a Chinese theory innovation in terms of dispute resolution systems for the international exploration of seabed resources and development activities [118]. To realize the sharing of biogenetic resources in international seabed areas among mankind and the value objective of the MCSF, analyzing the application of the principle of the common heritage of mankind based on international law and identifying the legal dilemma and path for breaking the application of this principle to biogenetic resources in international seabed areas is necessary [119]. Qin Guanwen and Feng Jinlong comment that the concept of a marine community of destiny, as proposed by China, provides a new strategy for improving the resource development regime of international seabed areas. The benefit-sharing regime of marine genetic resources, which exceeds national jurisdiction, is the most divergent one in terms of subject, scope, and mode of sharing. The concept of a marine community of destiny should be taken as the guiding principle, and its value should be followed for benefit sharing [120]. Moreover, the design of this regime should be improved to accelerate the negotiation process [121].

At the present stage, international governance on deep-sea security

faces problems, such as the insufficient diversity of governance subjects and insufficient governance in traditional security fields (e.g., military). In this case, China should further elucidate issues related to deep-sea security in terms of governance and build the relevant CSFM [122]. Moreover, the academic community lacks research on marine plastic pollution in the deep-sea domain; however, the urgency of the management of deep-sea plastic pollution requires a review of the rule design of the existing governance mechanisms. Guided by the theory of the CSFM, Tou Xiaodong and Zhao Wenping put forward proposals to deepen international cooperation on the environmental protection of the deep sea, strengthen scientific and technological innovation in the management of deep-sea plastic pollution, and strengthen the Chinese expression on environmental protection with regard to the deep sea [123]. Zhao Qiang and Wang Hongli suggest that, 'the development of deep-sea marine energy is of great importance' in promoting the MCSF, and through the gradual construction of the blue energy community of several big oceans, the global community of blue energy destiny will be finally built [124].

The rules of international marine technology transfer are of great significance in international maritime cooperation, technology development, and other perspectives. However, attention and research on these aspects still need to be strengthened. Zhang Lina uses the concept of the MCSF to review the rules of international marine technology transfer [125]. The author believes that problems, such as value consensus, responsibility sharing, and benefit sharing, should be guided by the concept of the MCSF. Specifically, it needs to confront the attributes of intellectual property rights, expand and improve the mode of technology transfer, and implement the mandatory obligation of special technology transfer.

3.2. Approaches to building the MCSF in the promotion of ocean governance from the domestic perspective

3.2.1. Policy and law

A review of policies and laws related to the MCSF is a well-established approach when the intention is to understand the activities of the construction of the MCSF within China due to the unique state and political structure of the country. Against this background, many scholars have interpreted, analyzed, and assessed policies and laws on the construction of the MCSF in China.

The CCP's 100-year view of the ocean presents important practical significance for building a strong ocean state by participating in global ocean governance and building an MCSF [126]. After successive national leaders have supplemented and developed the ocean discourse, China has formed a general pattern using three important theoretical pillars, namely, building an ocean power, building a 21st-century maritime silk road, and building the MCSF [127]. The six essential characteristics of General Secretary Xi Jinping's Ocean discourse are strong country, sea road, economic strategy, peace, public, and tolerance [128]. From the perspective of institution building, the main tasks for realizing the MCSF at the primary, intermediate, and advanced stages are to complete the integration and unification of domestic and foreign maritime legal systems, promote regional unified maritime conventions, and follow or even lead in formulating relevant maritime international conventions [129]. Looking ahead, China needs to make further efforts in the areas of territorial sovereignty, maritime awareness, and maritime cultural self-confidence. In this manner, it can accelerate the realization of the strategic goal of a strong maritime nation [130]. On the premise of formulating a unified basic law of the sea as soon as possible, China should connect with relevant international conventions and common rules to establish a complete legal system of maritime rights and interests [131].

3.2.2. Marine environment governance

On the basis of grasping its characteristics, various measures should be taken to vigorously develop the marine economy, promote the construction of marine ecological civilization, and promote the formation of the MCSF [132]. Shi Yuanhua and Chen Miaoling state that the friction between certain neighboring countries and China over maritime rights and interests has increased simultaneously with the continued involvement of extraterritorial powers in China's neighboring regions in maritime affairs [133]. Moreover, China's peaceful emergence faces severe tests from its neighboring situation. Lu Jian and Guan Huiwen believe that, the concept of MCSF provides a new guiding idea for China to enhance its maritime discourse, and it is important to seize the opportunity to actively consider and explore the path to enhance China's maritime discourse in the new era [134]. Lv Ming contends that, the MCSF clarifies that the object of universal jurisdiction protection is the community legal interest, constructs a new view of obligation, and takes respect for the sovereignty of the flag state as an important limitation of universal jurisdiction, thus completing the jurisprudential transmutation of universal jurisdiction [135].

Establishing a new partnership of 'equality, mutual consultation and understanding' to encourage countries worldwide to consciously assume the important responsibility of protecting the oceans and the earth is the path to building the MCSF [136]. President Xi makes relevant deployments to enhance the capacity of China in terms of maritime security governance in relation to infrastructure construction, diversification of main forces, improving legal supply, and strengthening scientific and technological innovation [137]. Hao Suyu suggests that China's maritime strategy should be unified with the concept of the CSFM [138]. Moreover, it should adhere to the basic principle of mutually beneficial cooperation and the win–win scenario, emerge from a mutually beneficial and symbiotic, sustainable development of a strong country, and build a strong maritime nation with Chinese characteristics. The new ocean concept attaches great importance to the important role of the sea in the overall development of the country and adheres to the idea of land and sea integration. In addition, it appropriately handles the relationship between the maintenance of maritime rights and stability, promotes the concept of harmony between people and the sea, and advocates the building of the MCSF. The new ocean concept provides a guiding ideology for China's maintenance of its maritime rights and participation in international ocean governance. Lastly, it points the way forward for the reconstruction of an international ocean order, which implies extremely important theoretical and practical significance [139].

The study on the MCSF is gradually transitioning from conceptual advocacy and theoretical discussion to practical construction. The construction of a pilot zone for the MCSF is a positive endeavor and demonstration. For example, the construction of the Qingdao MCSF pilot zone can follow three paths, namely, international fisheries cooperation, port park interoperability, and city co-business sharing [140]. To further transform the ocean governance system into effective ocean governance, adherence to the leadership of the Party in terms of the cause of a strong ocean state should be observed at the onset and by building a national ocean culture and constructing the MCSF [141].

3.2.3. Port governance

The different legal systems and legal customs of individual countries have led to many legal problems in the process of maritime cooperation or normal maritime activities. This scenario renders international maritime cooperation inefficient, one example being port governance.

A review of mechanisms for port cooperation in the South China Sea reveals real problems such as the lack of cooperation ideas, insufficient coordination among mechanisms, and the lack of enforceability of specific rules. To address the shortcomings of the existing cooperation mechanisms, introducing the concept of the MCSF as one of righteousness and methodology is necessary to build consensus on development cooperation among cooperating countries, construct a unified regional cooperation mechanism, and take pragmatic measures to provide high-quality public goods via ports [142]. Through the analysis of the development of international financial centers in the past ten years, the literature found an obvious trend in the oceanization of global financial

centers, where marine finance is the core driving force and new growth pole of developing marine economies. As such, China should focus on the construction of marine financial centers, which suggests the construction of a third financial center in the Bohai Bay area. In this manner, a marine financial center with exemplary significance can be created, and a financial hub in the Bohai Bay area and a coastal financial center belt can be formed, which, overall, will enhance the influence of marine finance [143]. The institutional dilemma of the transportation safety legislation for international passenger ships is manifested in three levels, namely, ship safety, traffic safety, and personnel safety. Scholars suggest that the principles of biological risk prevention, the balance between ship and shore interests, and international cooperation should be followed at the level of the legislative concept. Moreover, the rules of the transportation safety legislation for international passenger ships should be reconstructed by improving the existing institutional rules and by formulating a special international convention at the level of immediate and long-term reconstruction [144]. Flag and port states face the risk of international liability for potential epidemics during cruise ship voyages, the spread of epidemics during cruise ship quarantine in port, and the spread of epidemics in other countries due to inadequate measures after the expiration of cruise ship quarantine. This dilemma reflects gaps in coordination between legislation and international maritime conventions for international public health emergencies and the UNCLOS. In addition to the international maritime legal system, building the maritime legal system in China should focus on the construction of prevention and control mechanisms for epidemics among cruise ship homeports and the improvement of the relevant legal system. Under the guidance of the CSFM concept, sharing of epidemic information across borders, law enforcement entities, and international cooperation mechanisms should be optimized to better respond to the above-mentioned issues [145].

3.2.4. Provinces

After the proposal of the MCSF, the relevant practical development undergone a process from central to local and from theory to practice. Analysis of the practices of specific provinces under the instruction of the MCSF concept indicates that it can positively enrich the MCSF and realize it on a larger scale. Based on the practice of each province, inferring that each local area was able to work with dynamism is possible by taking advantage of its unique characteristic.

The construction of a free-trade port in Hainan will certainly promote geopolitical and economic cooperation, especially maritime cooperation, between Hainan and countries or regions around the South China Sea. In this manner, establishing a new model of maritime governance and building the MCSF in the South China Sea is a good option [146]. Yu Tao and Chen Xiangmiao find that, in the process of building the MCSF acrosss the South China Sea, Hainan Province can 'optimize its spatial and industrial layout by scientifically planning the development of marine industry, relying on the top-level design of the government and guided by the special policy arrangements of free trade port with Chinese characteristics' [147].

The MCSF concept and the maritime synergy development of the Guangdong–Hong Kong–Macao–Great Bay Area (GBA) play an important role in regional coordinated development strategies. The seven strategies for the coordinated development of the GBA based on the MCSF concept are proposed, which include the establishment of ocean cooperation and coordination mechanism and the strengthening of the integrated planning of ocean-related industrial cooperation, among others [148]. GBA will perform an important role in the diverse dimension of China. At the current stage, Chinese policymakers should fill the legal gaps and provide additional legal support to meet the need for further legal instruments and a more solid legal basis for integration and cooperation in the GBA [149]. The Northeast Asian Community brings opportunities and challenges for the development of the marine economy in Liaoning. By analyzing its current situation in terms of development, scholars found that its high-quality development requires the strengthening of the legislation and policy guarantee of the supply-side structural reform. In addition, the formulation of regional laws and policies for the cooperative development of the marine economy and the comprehensive management of the marine environment need to be accelerated [150]. Guangdong exhibits a unique geographical advantage, a good regional environment for innovation in science and technology, and an open and tolerant marine culture, which lay a good foundation for building the MCSF. As a large marine economy province, Guangdong holds an important strategic significance in implementing the MCSF. Thus, Guangdong should strive to achieve the sustainable use of marine resources by integrating land and sea, accelerating the construction of a modern marine industrial system, strengthening the construction of a marine ecological civilization, deepening and enhancing the confidence of marine culture, and actively participating in global marine governance [151].

4. Conclusion

The study conducted a review of the literature on the MCSF and found that the MCSF has a dual nature. The first is a political one that emphasizes the leadership role of China in international relations and the world political stage. The second is the legal nature, which makes the MCSF subject to different interpretations and applications under diverse legal contexts. The proposal of the MCSF indicates China's domestic needs for a new maritime framework in different eras of development as well as the development of the ocean view from that of a harmonious one to 'a strong maritime country' [152]. Through China's international influence on the world's oceans and the perception of other countries about China's maritime role, the study observed that the main characteristic of Chinese studies on the MCSF is comprehensive and governance-oriented, which generally presents positive responses or active interpretation and application of the MCSF. According to Chinese scholars, the MCSF, as a marine governance concept, draws inspiration from the current theory of global ocean governance. However, it is not limited to that theory. In addition to examining drawbacks of current global ocean governance theory, Chinese researchers recommend that the MCSF be incorporated into global ocean governance in order to enhance it. In view of this, Chinese scholars aims to provide a better and updated understanding of global ocean governance with the support of the MCSF. Notably, in 2022, UNCLOS celebrates its 40th anniversary of adoption. Chinese scholars extensively recall China's contributions to develop the UNCLOS, stating that the MCSF should be built as a new instrument to improve ocean governance on a global scale [153].

Nevertheless, the situation differed for foreign scholars who did not highly discuss the MCSF. This paper aims to introduce Chinese academic works to international scholars outside China and to increase their attention to Chinese new maritime vision. Yang Wei reazlizes that the foreign communication of the MCSF remains at the low level and is not widely disseminated to the outside world. Additionally, the credibility and validity of external communication paths also need to be improved [154]. Many Chinese scholars have suggested the transformation of the building of the MCSF to China's discourse power in the international community [155]. In order to implement the MCSF, countries should work together to tackle maritime issues with a cooperative attitude, seek practical paths, and provide institutional support and cooperation platforms by international organizations through the formulation and implementation of international rules [156]. Some pragamatic approaches has been carried out by China, though such implementation is just starting, the realization of Chinese future maritime vision remains to be seen in the future.

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Conflicts of Interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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